
Premier League and Carabao Cup final: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Premier League and Carabao Cup final: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Plenty of pep in Guardiola's step

One theory behind Manchester City's subpar 18 months is that the end is sliding into view on Pep Guardiola's glorious reign, and the fact that he may be considering life after City is transmitting itself to his players. Sunday's Carabao Cup win goes some way to refuting that. Not only did he see off the challenge of his former apprentice Mikel Arteta, but it was vintage Guardiola on the touchline. He looked gobsmacked when decisions didn't go his side's way, produced a Chuck Norris tribute kick to an advertising hoarding when City took the lead then sprinted down the touchline, fists pumping, when Nico O'Reilly scored his second of a fairytale final for the club's local lad. If Guardiola's intense level of care has dropped, he's disguising it well. Anybody writing off him – and City's league title ambitions – would do well to remember just what level of manager we are dealing with here. **Alex Reid**

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Match report: [Arsenal 0-2 Manchester City](#)

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Woefully flat Arsenal must show bounce

Arsenal finally lose a game (that really matters). Throughout a high-flying but still inconsistent season, Arteta has raised his team after setbacks. Dropped points in the [Premier League](#) have usually been followed up by a run of good results; a drab display in Leverkusen led to Arsenal dominating the second leg in the Champions League last 16. But defeat in a final leaves no recourse to rally in that competition. Victory on Sunday would have delivered the double delight of a first League Cup since 1993 and relieved pressure by putting some silverware in the cabinet. It's simple to write off this defeat in isolation – Kepa Arrizabalaga's error led to Manchester City's breakthrough and he will be replaced by a superior goalkeeper in David Raya – but that cannot mask an insipid performance. Arteta has to lift his side and the players must show their mettle after the international break. This is the biggest test yet of Arsenal's bouncebackability. **AR**

Smooth Sangaré douses Spurs' fire

In what has been a very disappointing season for [Nottingham Forest](#), one of the few positives has been the form of Ibrahim Sangaré. The Côte d'Ivoire midfielder is 28 now and at something like his peak. Despite missing a month while away at the Africa Cup of Nations, he's already played more games this season than in either of his previous two campaigns in England. His partnership with Elliot Anderson at the back of midfield works very well, Sangaré playing the role for Anderson that Anderson does for Declan Rice with England. He sits off, reading the game, filling space, distributing sensibly, providing the platform for his partner to go hunting the ball. Dominic Solanke, dropping into Sangaré's space, barely got a look in, and neither did the substitute Xavi Simons. **Jonathan Wilson**

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Match report: [Tottenham 0-3 Nottingham Forest](#)

Mainoo revival needs support at United

Kobbie Mainoo's resurrection is one of the success stories of Michael Carrick's 10-game [Manchester United](#) reign. There was talk of a loan move as Ruben Amorim lost faith in the local lad, a betrayal of club lore that Carrick has corrected, with a new contract in the offing. The interim manager knows a fair bit about being a playmaking, deep-lying midfielder. Before the weekend Mainoo won him an England recall, likely at the expense of Bournemouth's Alex Scott, who was named in Thomas Tuchel's squad in November. On Friday night, Scott was much the more impressive performer, United's midfield and defence discomfited by his gliding perpetual motion. Carrick's team have a deficit of muscle in that department, hence weekend links with Newcastle's Bruno Guimarães. Striking a deal with a club that so reluctantly and painfully lost Alexander Isak would be difficult but a Casemiro replacement tops United's priorities. Mainoo needs physical power and knowhow alongside him to show his best. **John Brewin**

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Match report: [Bournemouth 2-2 Manchester United](#)

The penalty for imaginary cards

There has been a lot of talk recently about double standards and referees biased towards home teams. Fabian Hürzeler shared his frustrations at another playing field that he feels isn't level. The Brighton manager was shown a yellow card for waving an imaginary card and questioning why Alexis Mac Allister hadn't been booked during their win against [Liverpool](#), just before the Argentinian had his name taken. "It's too harsh," Hürzeler said afterwards. "If I see how others behave, and I behave like this and immediately get a yellow card, it's nonsense. I said nothing. I was asking why in this case the opponent didn't get a yellow card for the foul. It was the only questions I made." It was pointed out to him that the rulebook states the gesture warrants a booking. "But even then I can say to you other managers in the league they do it as well," he said. "There is a clear rule but then you have to do it for everyone." He has a point – other managers are forever waving imaginary cards on the touchline and aren't punished. Hürzeler, however, will now be suspended for two games. **Sam Cunningham**

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Match report: [Brighton 2-1 Liverpool](#)

Garner garners praise after call-up

David Moyes hopes James Garner "comes back an even better player" from his introduction to the England squad. The 25-year-old's first call-up on Friday has already had an effect judging by his commanding display against [Chelsea](#). Garner has impressed for Everton all season – much longer in fact, and in a variety of roles – but anyone questioning Thomas Tuchel's selection will have found their answer on Saturday as the midfielder underpinned the best home win, amid the best atmosphere, at Hill Dickinson Stadium so far. Garner's pass for Beto's opening goal was exquisite but there was also a confidence and intelligence to the performance that elevated the £15m signing from Manchester United above Enzo Fernández and Moisés Caicedo. "He was on England's radar before Christmas and didn't quite make it," said Moyes. "So he has had to keep his form up from November to March and he has. If you think about the levels of the players he's competed against – Enzo Fernández, Elliot Anderson at Nottingham Forest or Declan Rice at Arsenal – he's doing a brilliant job." **Andy Hunter**

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Match report: [Everton 3-0 Chelsea](#)

Torres delivers a World Cup reminder

As Pau Torres reached 100 appearances for [Aston Villa](#), could his continued prominence in Aston Villa's push for Champions League qualification through the Europa League and their Premier League placing propel him towards a recall for Spain's World Cup squad? Torres joined Villa in the summer of 2023 from Villarreal, but the defender has been out of the international picture for the past two years. Back in the side for Villa's return to winning ways this week, his upturn in form lead may him back into Luis de la Fuente's squad for his second consecutive World Cup. While De la Fuente has experienced options such as Aymeric Laporte and Robin Le Normand, as well as the element of youth in Dean Huijsen and Pau Cubarsí, Torres does have the leverage of competing in the ultra-competitive Premier League. **Peter Lansley**

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Match report: [Aston Villa 2-0 West Ham](#)

Le Fée shows Newcastle what they lack

Not for the first time this season, Newcastle started well but the inaccuracy of their passing ultimately betrayed them. After [Sunderland](#) came from behind to win 2-1 at St James' Park and complete a league double over their north-east neighbours, Eddie Howe conceded there had been a "lack of quality" in a home midfield without the injured Sandro Tonali, Bruno Guimarães and Lewis Miley. Régis Le Bris's side were even harder hit by injuries and, in Melker Ellborg, fielded their second-choice goalkeeper. But, as they gradually took control of the game and Brian Brobbey shone at centre-forward, their superiority on the ball was highlighted. Few visiting players can pick a killer pass better than Enzo Le Fée and, appropriately enough, a playmaker newly recovered from injury stepped off the bench to provide the excellent assist for a 90th-minute winner from the outstanding Brobbey. Given he stands only 5ft 7in, Le Fée is not the type of player Howe's Newcastle currently tend to sign but his touch and vision highlighted their creative shortcomings. Being fast and physical can only take you so far. **Louise Taylor**

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Match report: [Newcastle 1-2 Sunderland](#)

Jiménez feints draw Burnley dismay

Raúl Jiménez maintained his 100% penalty record in the Premier League (14 goals from 14 attempts) to seal Fulham's 3-1 win over [Burnley](#). Josh Laurent pushed Jiménez in the last minute, receiving a red card for his troubles, to give the Mexican striker the opportunity to complete Fulham's comeback from the spot after goals from Josh King and Harry Wilson. Jiménez trotted towards the ball, taking a couple of steps backwards and forwards, then backwards and forwards again, before smashing it into the top corner, much to the dismay of the Burnley players. Feinting a penalty run-up is controversial but legal. According to Law 14 of the FA's rulebook "feinting in the run-up is permitted" but not once the run-up has been completed. Jiménez's staggered penalty was an extra special one as it came a week after his father's death was announced by the Mexican Football Federation. He fell to his knees and raised his hands to the sky in celebration. **Xaymaca Awoyungbo**

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Match report: [Fulham 3-1 Burnley](#)

Bees desperate to rediscover their buzz

Brentford showed little ambition in [their goalless draw with Leeds](#) on Saturday night. They never looked like scoring from start to finish, were happy to waste time and desperately hoping a set piece would provide a goal. But it never came, nor were they even close. One problem for them is a lack of squad depth, meaning they could not change things off the bench. Of their nine substitutes, five had not made a Premier League appearance and another could boast only 38 minutes across four cameos. Brentford are still pushing for Europe but their injury list could be the difference between qualifying and falling short. The international break and the FA Cup means it will be three weeks until they play again on 11 April, allowing them to nurse some back to health, and it will be necessary because it does not feel like the squad can carry on grinding out draws. **Will Unwin**

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Match report: [Leeds 0-0 Brentford](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	31	39	70
2	Man City	30	32	61
3	Man Utd	31	13	55
4	Aston Villa	31	5	54
5	Liverpool	31	8	49
6	Chelsea	31	15	48
7	Brentford	31	4	46
8	Everton	31	2	46
9	Fulham	31	-1	44
10	Brighton	31	4	43
11	Sunderland	31	-4	43
12	Newcastle	31	-1	42
13	AFC Bournemouth	31	-2	42
14	Crystal Palace	30	-2	39
15	Leeds	31	-11	33
16	Nottm Forest	31	-12	32
17	Tottenham Hotspur	31	-10	30
18	West Ham	31	-21	29
19	Burnley	31	-28	20
20	Wolverhampton	31	-30	17

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